

Chapter 2

Culture and Social Movements

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Over the past two decades, the study of social movements has been among the most productive and intellectually lively subfields within sociology. But, as with all emergent paradigms, the recent renaissance in social movement studies has highlighted certain aspects of the phenomenon while ignoring others. Specifically, the dominance, within the United States, of the "resource mobilization" and "political process" perspectives has privileged the political, organizational, and network/structural aspects of social movements while giving the more cultural or ideational dimensions of collective action short shrift.

From a sociology of knowledge perspective, the recent ignorance of the more cultural aspects of social movements is the result of the rejection of the classical collective behavior paradigm, which emphasized the role of shared beliefs and identities but whose hints of irrationality and pathology (Klapp 1969; Lang and Lang 1961; Smelser 1962) made it unattractive to a new generation of scholars whose own experiences led them to view social movements as a form of rational political action. Whatever the reason, the absence of any real emphasis on ideas, ideology, or identity has created, within the United States, a strong "rationalist" and "structural" bias in the current literature on social movements. At the most macro level of analysis, social movements are seen to emerge in response to the "expansion in political opportunities" that grant formal social movement organizations (SMOs) and movement entrepreneurs the opportunity to engage in successful "resource mobilization." At the micro level, individuals are drawn into participation not by the force of the ideas or even individual attitudes but as the result of their embeddedness in associational networks that render them "structurally available" for protest ac-

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tivity. Until recently, "culture," in all of its manifestations, was rarely invoked by American scholars as a force in the emergence and development of social movements. The renewed interest in the topic has been spurred, in part, by the European "new social movement" perspective, which has made cultural and cognitive factors central to the study of social movements (Brand 1990; Eyerman and Jamison 1991; Melucci 1985, 1989).

This chapter broadens the discourse among movement scholars by focusing on some of the links between culture and social movements. Specifically, I address three broad topics: the cultural roots of social movements, the emergence and development of distinctive "movement cultures," and the cultural consequences of social movements.

The Cultural Roots of Social Movements

The "structural bias" in movement studies is most evident in recent American work on the emergence of social movements and revolutions. With but a few exceptions, recent theorizing on the question has located the roots of social movements in some set of political, economic, or organizational factors. While acknowledging the importance of such factors, I add cultural factors and processes to this list as important constraints or facilitators of collective action. There are three distinct ways in which culture can be said to facilitate movement emergence.

Framing as an Act of Cultural Appropriation

Drawing on the work of Erving Goffman (1974), David Snow and various of his colleagues (Snow et al. 1986; Snow and Benford 1988) have developed the concept of "frame alignment processes" to describe the efforts by which organizers seek to join the cognitive orientations of individuals with those of social movement organizations. The task is to propound a view of the world that both legitimates and motivates protest activity. The success of such efforts is determined, in part, by the *cultural resonance* of the frames advanced by organizers. In this sense, framing efforts can be thought of as acts of cultural appro-

priation, with movement leaders seeking to tap highly resonant ideational strains in mainstream society (or in a particular target subculture) as a way of galvanizing activism.

Much has been made of Martin Luther King, Jr.'s use of Gandhian nonviolence as an ideological cornerstone of the civil rights movement. In fact, King's interest in and advocacy of Gandhi's philosophy was largely irrelevant to the rapid emergence and spread of the civil rights struggle. Far more significant was King's appropriation and powerful evocation of highly resonant cultural themes, not only in the southern black Baptist tradition, but in American political culture more generally.

Consider King's "I have a Dream" speech. Juxtaposing the poetry of the scriptural prophets—"I have a dream that every valley shall be exalted, every hill and mountain shall be made low"—with the lyrics of patriotic anthems—"This will be the day when all of God's children will be able to sing with new meaning, 'My country 'tis of thee, sweet land of liberty, of thee I sing'"—King's oration reappropriated that classic strand of the American tradition that understands the true meaning of freedom to lie in the affirmation of responsibility for uniting all of the diverse members of society into a just social order. (Bellah et al. 1985, 249)

Indeed, this was King's unique genius: to frame civil rights activity in a way that resonated not only with the culture of the oppressed but with the culture of the oppressor as well. King successfully mobilized Southern blacks while he generated considerable sympathy and support for the movement among whites as well.

The student democracy movement in Beijing in the spring of 1989 also drew on deeply resonant cultural themes and traditions in the early days of the struggle. The initial march on April 27 that stimulated the movement was ostensibly organized to mark and mourn the death of former premier Yu Yaobang. Such public displays of respect and veneration for departed leaders (and the dead more generally) have deep roots in Chinese political culture. By framing the march as an act of public mourning, movement organizers appropriated long-standing cultural symbols in the service of the movement. This helps explain both the large size of the initial march and the surprising restraint exercised by Communist party leaders in dealing with the students. The cultural legitimacy that attached to the march encouraged participation while constraining official efforts at social control.

*Expanding Cultural Opportunities
as a Stimulus to Action*

Scholars such as Charles Tilly (1978), Sidney Tarrow (1994), Doug McAdam (1982), Theda Skocpol (1979), Jack Goldstone (1991), Hanspeter Kriesi (1990), and Herbert Kitschelt (1986), among others, have established the notion that social movements/revolutions often emerge in response to an expansion in the "political opportunities" available to a particular challenging group. The argument is that movements are less the product of meso level mobilization efforts than they are the beneficiaries of the increasing political vulnerability or receptivity of their opponents or of the political and economic system as a whole.

Although I generally concur with this view, I think it betrays a "structural" or "objectivist" bias in many of its specific formulations. It is extremely hard to separate these objective shifts in political opportunities from the subjective processes of social construction and collective attribution that render them meaningful. In other words, "expanding political opportunities . . . do not, in any simple sense, produce a social movement. . . . [Instead] they only offer insurgents a certain objective 'structural potential' for collective political action. Mediating between opportunity and action are people and the subjective meanings they attach to their situations" (McAdam 1982, 48).

The causal importance of expanding political opportunities, then, is inseparable from the collective definitional processes by which the meaning of these shifts is assigned and disseminated. Given this linkage, the movement analyst has two tasks: accounting for the structural factors that have objectively strengthened the challenger's hand, and analyzing the processes by which the meaning and attributed significance of shifting political conditions is assessed. This latter task prompts speculation about the existence and significance of expanding cultural opportunities in the emergence of collective action. By "expanding cultural opportunities" we have in mind specific events or processes that are likely to stimulate the kind of collective framing efforts mentioned above. A close reading of the historical literature on social movements suggests that framing efforts may be set in motion by at least four distinct types of expanding cultural opportunities.

Ideological or Cultural Contradictions. The first type of cultural opportunity involves any event or set of events

that dramatize a glaring contradiction between a highly resonant cultural value and conventional social practices. Many such examples can be found in the social movement literature. For example, the contrast between the egalitarian rhetoric and the sexist practices of the early American abolitionist movement have long been regarded as an important impetus in the development of the nineteenth-century women's rights movement. As Sara Evans (1980) and others have argued, much the same thing happened in regard to the women's liberation movement of the 1960s and 1970s. In this case, it was the egalitarian rhetoric and forms of sexual discrimination evident within the civil rights movement and the white student Left that fueled the development of a radical feminist "frame" legitimating protest activity.

One final example of the facilitating effect of this kind of ideological or cultural contradiction can be seen in regard to the threatened 1940 march on Washington. A. Philip Randolph, the president of the American Association of Sleeping Car Porters, organized a mass march on Washington to protest discriminatory labor practices in the defense industries. The apparent spur to action in this case was the glaring contradiction between President Franklin D. Roosevelt's growing anti-Nazi rhetoric—especially its "master race" philosophy—and his own tacit acceptance of racial discrimination at home (Fishel and Quarles 1970; Sitkoff 1978).

Suddenly Imposed Grievances. Another cognitive stimulus to framing processes comes from what Edward Walsh (1981) has called "suddenly imposed grievances." The term describes those dramatic, highly publicized, and generally unexpected events—human-made disasters, major court decisions, official violence—that increase public awareness of and opposition to previously accepted societal conditions. As an example of this process, Walsh (1981) cites and analyzes the generation of anti-nuclear power activity in the area of Three Mile Island following a 1979 accident there. Bert Useem's (1980) analysis of a movement in Boston during the mid 1970s aimed at stopping the busing of school children to achieve school desegregation leaves little doubt that the resistance was set in motion by a highly publicized court order mandating busing. Harvey Molotch (1970) documents a similar rise in protest activity among residents of Santa Barbara, California, in the wake of a major oil spill that took place in 1969.

The initial verdict in the Rodney King beating case (Los Angeles, California, April 1992) is as another example of a highly dramatic event spurring protest activity.

Dramatizations of System Vulnerability. Another "cultural" or "cognitive opportunity" that may stimulate increased framing and other mobilization efforts are those events or processes that highlight the vulnerability of one's political opponents. For example, the unanimous 1954 U.S. Supreme Court decision in *Brown v. Board of Education* declaring racially segregated schools unconstitutional convinced many in the black community of the political and legal vulnerability of the southern system of segregation and, in turn, accelerated the pace of civil rights organizing nationwide (Gerber 1962; McAdam 1982).

The collapse of Communist party rule in Poland and the unwillingness of Mikhail Gorbachev to use military force to suppress the Solidarity movement was widely interpreted throughout Eastern Europe as a sign that all Communist regimes in the region were in trouble. This is not to deny the deep structural roots of the crisis in the Soviet Union (see Tarrow 1991), but a crisis needs to be transparent if it is to serve as a cue for collective action. The end of communist rule in Poland served as just such a cue. This pivotal event led, in turn, to increased framing and other mobilization activities by reformers in all of the Warsaw Pact countries.

Finally, the ineffectual 1991 coup attempt by Soviet hardliners made it clear just how weak and out of touch the once formidable Communist party bosses had become, thus emboldening citizens from across the USSR to step up demands for political independence and economic reform.

The Availability of Master Frames. Finally, one other cultural opportunity has the potential to set in motion framing efforts and mobilization more generally. This is the availability of what David Snow and Robert Benford (1988) term "master protest frames" legitimating collective action. Movement scholars continue to err in viewing social movements as discrete social phenomena. Instead, movements tend to cluster in time and space precisely because they are not independent of one another (McAdam and Rucht 1993). To illustrate, the major movements of the 1960s in the United States were not so much independent entities

as offshoots of a single broad activist community with its roots squarely in the civil rights movement (McAdam 1988). One of the things that clearly linked the various struggles during this period was the existence of a "master protest frame" that was appropriated by each succeeding insurgent group. The source of this frame was the civil rights movement, but in short order the other major movements of the period used the ideological understandings and cultural symbols of the black struggle as the ideational basis for their efforts as well. Evans (1980) has documented the ideological/cultural links between the women's liberation and civil rights movements, while Doug McAdam (1988) has done the same for the black struggle and the antiwar and student movements. The ideological imprint of the civil rights movement is also clear in regard to the gay rights, American Indian, farmworkers, and other leftist movements of the period. All of these groups, drawing heavily upon the "civil rights master frame," came to define themselves as victims of discrimination and, as such, deserving of expanded rights and protection under the law. They mapped their understandings of their own situations on the general framework first put forward by civil rights activists.

The same point applies with equal force to other periods of heightened movement activity. The rash of student movements that flourished around the globe (for example, in Spain, Mexico, Japan, France, Italy, Germany, and the United States) in 1968 were clearly attuned to and influenced by one another, resulting in the development and diffusion of a "student left master frame" (Caute 1988; Katsiaficas 1987).

In similar fashion, the success of Solidarity in finally breaking the Communist party's forty-four-year monopoly on power in Poland encouraged other Eastern European dissidents to adopt prodemocracy frames in their own countries. The same process can be seen in the former Soviet Union, with the success of independence movements in the Baltic states encouraging the rise of ideologically similar ethnic nationalist movements in many of the other former Soviet republics.

The more general theoretical point is that successful framing efforts are almost certain to inspire other groups to reinterpret their situation in light of the available master frame and to mobilize based on their new understanding of themselves and the world around them. Thus, the presence of such a frame constitutes yet

another cultural or ideological resource that facilitates movement emergence.

*The Role of Long-Standing Activist Subcultures
in Movement Emergence*

Movement scholars have focused a great deal of attention on the role of existing organizations or associational networks in the emergence of protest activity (Freeman 1973; Gould 1991; McAdam 1982, 1986; Morris 1984; Oberschall 1973; Rosenthal et al. 1985). This literature betrays the "structural bias" of the field as a whole. Virtually all of these authors attribute the importance of prior organization to the concrete organizational resources, that is, leaders, communication networks, and meeting places, that such groups provide. Established organizations, however, are the source of cultural resources as well.

In other words, what is too often overlooked in structural accounts of movement emergence is the extent to which these established organizations/networks are themselves embedded in long-standing activist subcultures capable of sustaining the ideational traditions needed to revitalize activism following a period of movement dormancy. These enduring activist subcultures function as repositories of cultural materials into which succeeding generations of activists can dip to fashion ideologically similar, but chronologically separate, movements. To use Ann Swidler's (1986) term, these subcultures represent the specialized "tool kits" of enduring activist traditions. The presence of these enduring cultural repertoires frees new generations of would-be activists from the necessity of constructing new movement frames from whole cloth. Instead, most new movements rest on the ideational and broader cultural base of ideologically similar past struggles. To assert such continuity is to take issue with certain new social movement theorists (Melucci 1989) who hold that the movements of the 1960s and 1970s represented a total break with past activism. That these movements extended and modified existing activist traditions is undeniable. At the same time, it seems clear that they were initially rooted in the very traditions they subsequently transcended. Examples of these kinds of cross-generational continuities in movement activity are numerous.

In all western industrial nations, for example, the tradition of labor activism has served as a broad cultural template available

to succeeding generations of workers as a resource supporting mobilization. In similar fashion, several generations of American peace movements have drawn on a rich pacifist tradition, as nurtured and sustained by a combination of religious denominations (for example, Quakers and Unitarians) and secular-humanist organizations (for example, American Friends Service Committee and Fellowship of Reconciliation). At the other end of the political spectrum, an enduring tradition of antiimmigrant and white supremacist activism has served as a broad "tool kit" encouraging American right-wing movements over many generations. Finally, in Spain, long-standing separatist traditions in both Catalonia and the Basque region have served as the wellspring from which several cycles of nationalist movements have flowed (see Johnston, Chapter 11).

Although the role of such long-standing activist subcultures has received little attention in studies of movement emergence, their imprint seems apparent. In his definitive study of the structural origins of the American civil rights movement, Aldon Morris (1984) documents the critical contribution made by what he terms "movement halfway houses." These were such established organizations as the Highlander Folk School and the Fellowship of Reconciliation that, despite intense repression, sustained earlier traditions of civil rights activism. They were available to play the role of organizational and cultural "midwives" in the "birth" of the new movement.

Leila Rupp and Verta Taylor (1987) provide a rich, detailed portrait of the survival of another enduring activist subculture—that of American feminism—during the long hiatus between the decline of the suffrage movement and the emergence of the contemporary women's movement. Like Morris, Rupp and Taylor focus on the crucial role of organizations and specific individuals in nurturing and sustaining an activist subculture during a period of movement dormancy. The result was the survival of a set of ideas, organizational practices, and activist traditions that served as one of the important "tool kits" shaping the cultural contours of modern American feminism.

Enrique Laraña (see Chapter 9) offers another example of cultural continuity in activist traditions. He documents the historical persistence of Marxist discourse and images of struggle in one of the two wings of the Spanish student movement. Howard Kim-

meldorf's (1989) comparative study of unionism among East and West Coast dockworkers has continued to shape the ideology and practices of the union to the present. Finally, the imprint of long-standing traditions of student activism are evident on a number of American college or university campuses. For example, one of the best predictors of which colleges and universities contributed student volunteers to the 1964 Mississippi Freedom Summer project was the presence of an active socialist or communist student organization on campus during the 1930s. It should come as no surprise that Berkeley and other colleges such as Antioch and Oberlin sent large contingents of volunteers to Mississippi in 1964. In doing so they were merely drawing on and perpetuating the localized activist subcultures that have long existed on and around those campuses.

Movement emergence, then, is never simply the result of some fortuitous combination of macropolitical opportunities and meso level organizational structures. While important, these factors only afford insurgents a certain structural potential for successful protest activity. Mediating between opportunities and concrete mobilization efforts are the shared meanings people bring to their lives. These meanings, in turn, are expected to be shaped by the cultural resources and opportunities mentioned above.

The Emergence and Development of a Movement Culture

An interest in the relationship between social movements and culture clearly transcends the emergent phase of collective action. Indeed, that relationship becomes more complicated and potentially more interesting as the movement develops because the direction of causal influence in the relationship can run both ways. Not only will the movement bear the imprint of the broader cultural context(s) in which it is embedded but insurgents are also likely to develop a distinctive movement culture capable of reshaping the broader cultural contours of mainstream society.

That such cultures do exist is intuitively clear to anyone who has participated in any but the most ephemeral of movements. Social movements tend to become worlds unto themselves that are characterized by distinctive ideologies, collective identities, behav-

ioral routines, and material cultures. The more thoroughgoing the goals of the movement are, the more likely it is that a movement culture will develop. This is not surprising. Having dared to challenge a particular aspect of mainstream society, there is implicit pressure on insurgents to engage in a kind of social engineering to suggest remedies to the problem. The challenge is to actualize within the movement the kind of social arrangements deemed preferable to those the group is opposing. Again, the more thoroughgoing the changes proposed, the more the tendency to conceive of the movement as an oppositional subculture—a kind of idealized community embodying the movement's alternative vision of social life.

Movement cultures are not static over time. Having opened up the question of the restructuring of social arrangements, there is no guarantee that insurgents will confine their attention to the specific issues or institutions originally targeted. When this happens, movements can take on the character of hothouses of cultural innovation. Anything and everything is open to critical scrutiny. Change becomes the order of the day.

At the moment, we lack any real theoretical or empirical understanding of the processes that shape the ongoing development of distinctive movement cultures, and such an understanding is beyond the scope of this chapter. We can begin to move in that direction by calling attention to two factors that would seem to influence the shifting character of a movement's culture.

Shifts in the Social Locus of the Movement

response Social movements typically develop within particular social and generational strata or geographic locations. The expectation is that the culture of the movement will, at least initially, reflect these social, generational, and geographic origins. Movements are hardly the property of those population segments who gave them life in the first place. On the contrary, it is not uncommon for the locus of protest activity to shift over the life of a movement. As such shifts occur, we should see a shift in the ideational and material culture of the movement that reflects the new class, regional, generational, or other social loci of the movement.

One example of this process comes from Lynn Hunt's (1984) definitive study, *Politics, Culture, and Class in the French Revolution*.

Hunt's work documents the dramatic shift in the dominant ideology and material symbols of the Revolution that accompanied the change in the class composition of the movement between 1789 and 1795. Dominated at the outset by the emerging bourgeoisie, intellectuals, and even elements of the aristocracy, by 1794–1795 control of the Revolution had passed to artisans, shopkeepers, lawyers, and other less class-privileged elements of French society.

An equally dramatic shift in the cultural content of a movement occurred in the American civil rights movement during the decade of the 1960s as a result of a fundamental shift in the class and geographic loci of protest activity. While the movement initially developed within the churches and other institutions of the Southern, urban, black middle class, by the late 1960s its "home" had shifted to the urban ghettos of a poorer and more secular Northern black community. Partly in response to this shift, the ideational and material culture of the movement became less religious in nature, more explicitly political, and more aggressively focused on the assertion of a shared and distinctive "cultural nationalism" among black Americans. This is not to say that these shifts were solely the product of the geographic and social changes, but they clearly played a part in the broader cultural transformation that occurred during these years.

Nancy Whittier (1993) provides a final example of the shifting cultural content of a movement in her analysis of generational replacement in the contemporary women's movement. Whittier argues persuasively that the very real differences in the cultural content and "tone" of the current movement have come about not because the pioneering feminists of the 1960s and 1970s have changed their collective identities but because new "activist cohorts" have entered the movement and brought distinctive cultural styles and identities to the struggle.

*Perceived Effectiveness of the
Movement's Dominant Core*

Successful movements tend to be fairly heterogeneous, drawing adherents from a variety of subgroups within the population. These subgroups will vie for cultural as well as strategic political influence over the movement. At any one time, however, it is usually possible to identify a particular segment within the movement as dominant. To the extent that this



➤ segment is widely perceived as substantively effective, its cultural "package" will likely be privileged as well. To the extent it is seen as ineffective, strategic and organizational control of the movement will likely shift (often following a period of conflict) to some other contender, thereby enhancing the importance of its cultural package.

The contemporary women's movement in the United States affords a prime example of this phenomenon. Initially, the movement coalesced around radical feminists with roots in both the American "New Left" and the "counterculture" of the 1960s. Eschewing formal organization and leadership, this wing of the movement pioneered the use of consciousness-raising groups as a form of activism. As effective as these groups were in drawing new recruits into the movement, they came to be seen by many as ineffective vehicles for pursuing political and economic change (Freeman 1973). Partly as a result of this critique, influence over the movement gradually shifted to an older, more politically and organizationally conventional group of women who were affiliated with the National Organization for Women (NOW). The results of this shift were cultural as much as political and organizational, with the countercultural affinities of the radical wing gradually giving way to the more conventional, professionalized ethos of NOW loyalists.

The Cultural Consequences of Movements

In assessing the impact of social movements, scholars have tended to focus their attention narrowly on political or economic consequences. Given the central importance attached to political or economic change by most social movements, this is certainly an important topic for systematic investigation. At the same time, resistance to significant political or economic change is likely to be sufficiently intense as to mute the material effects of all but the most successful movements. As many commentators have noted, even a movement as broad based and widely supported as the American civil rights movement failed to effect the fundamental redistribution in political and economic power that it ultimately sought. The opposition of the political and economic establishment to such a redistribu-

tion was simply too strong and too united to permit its occurrence.

Given the entrenched political and economic opposition movements are likely to encounter, it is often true that their biggest impact is more cultural than narrowly political and economic. Although the topic has never been systematically studied, the examples of movement-based cultural change would seem to be numerous and extraordinarily diverse. What follows is an impressionistic survey of some of these many changes. It is not exhaustive; it merely reflects the richness and diversity of the forms of cultural innovation that may be the result of movement dynamics.

As Ralph Turner reminds us (see Chapter 4), social movements have been the source of some of the most transformative ideologies or belief systems the world has ever known. We would do well to remember that Christianity, Islam, the Protestant Reformation, and subsequent sectarianism began life as the organizing frames for specific social movements. In many other cases, movements served as the principal vehicles by which belief systems, derived elsewhere, were modified and extended. So, for example, Marxist thought was profoundly shaped and deepened by figures associated with both the Russian (Lenin, Trotsky), Chinese (Mao Zedong, Jou Enlai, Lin Biao), and Cuban (Castro, Che Guevara) Revolutions. Through such figures as Voltaire and Rousseau in France and Thomas Paine and Thomas Jefferson in the American colonies, the French and American Revolutions had a similar impact on Enlightenment thinking.

Specific social movements can also give rise to what Snow and his colleagues (1986) call "master protest frames"; that is, ideological accounts legitimating protest activity that come to be shared by a variety of social movements. So, as noted earlier, the civil rights movement advanced a "civil rights" master frame that was, in turn, adopted by other movements as the ideological grounding for their efforts. These movements include the women's, gay rights, handicapped rights, and animal rights movements. The various revolutions in Eastern Europe have appropriated the "democracy frame" first advanced by the Solidarity movement in Poland.

Social movements have also served historically as the source for new collective identities within society. For example, the iden-

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ties Christian and Muslim emerged in the context of social movements. So, too, did that of the "working class" via the labor movement. In a more contemporary vein, the identity of "feminist" grew out of the modern women's movement. Indeed, many proponents of the new social movements perspective (Inglehart 1981, 1990; Melucci 1980, 1989; Offe 1985; Touraine 1981) argue that what is "new" about the new social movements—including the women's movement—is the central importance they attach to the creation of new collective identities as a fundamental goal of the movement. In fact, social movements have always served this function, whether it was an explicit goal of the movement or an unintended consequence of struggle.

Social movements have also been a force for innovation in strategic action forms. What began as emergent and often illegal tactics in yesterday's movements often become legitimate, institutionalized forms of politics in later years. The strike and the sit-in are two examples. Both tactics were pioneered in the labor movement, but later came to be recognized as legitimate forms of action by various groups. Elisabeth Clemens (1993) argues that the contemporary importance of lobbying owes historically to its successful and legitimating use by women activists in the period from 1880 to 1920.

Throughout history, social movements have also functioned as a source of new material cultural items. Hunt's (1984) cultural analysis of the French Revolution makes clear the extent to which popular symbols and the material culture of France were transformed during the Revolution. Virtually all political revolutions usher in cultural revolutions as well. The Chinese Revolution, for example, set in motion a thoroughgoing state effort to fashion a popular culture compatible with the ideals of the movement. The same thing has occurred more recently in Iran, with the Islamic Revolution ushering in a period of intense anti-Western feeling leading to the wholesale rejection of Western-style consumer goods and other cultural items. Ironically, the reverse process is currently underway in the Soviet Union, with the popular rejection of the Communist party encouraging a simultaneous process of Western-style cultural liberalization and experimentation.

Revolutions are not the only force that exert a powerful transformative effect on the material culture of a society. For example, the 1964 Mississippi Freedom Summer Project gave early expres-

sion to a number of specific cultural items that came to be associated with the 1960s counterculture (McAdam 1988). In general, as authors such as Morris Dickstein (1989) have shown, the counterculture and the movements of the 1960s had a profound effect on American popular culture. Dress and hairstyles, popular music, movies, dance, and theater were powerfully affected by the political turbulence of the era. The roots of the "drug culture" can also be found in the political and cultural movements of the 1960s. Language was affected; "black English" made inroads into popular English, and the feminist critique of the traditional vernacular prompted efforts to fashion more gender-neutral modes of expression.

Similar linguistic "insurgencies" are currently under way elsewhere. In the Canadian province of Quebec, French-speaking separatists affiliated with the Parti québécois have succeeded in making French the official provincial language. In Catalonia, separatists continue to press for the same designation for Catalan, underscoring their resolve by painting over street signs in Castilian with the equivalent word or phrase in Catalan.

To round out this survey, mention should be made of the effect of social movements on the culture and practices of mainstream institutions in society. In his thorough study of the impact of liberation theology on the Latin American Catholic church, Christian Smith (1991) provides a fascinating example of this process. Inspired in part by the spread of communist movements in the region, the liberation theology movement spawned a kind of revolution within the church that is still being waged today. In the United States, the movements of the 1960s have had a dramatic effect on the structure and curricular content of higher education in the United States. Structurally, the political turbulence of the era led to the establishment of African American, Native American, Hispanic, and women's studies programs on many college and university campuses. In addition, the heightened awareness of minorities spawned by the movements has resulted in far more curricular attention to minority groups in social science and humanities courses.

The forms of cultural change that flow from social movements are many and varied, and we know little about which factors or characteristics of movements account for the extent of their cultural impact. As a first approach to the question, I would

emphasize the role of four factors in mediating the cultural consequences of social movements. These factors are: the extensiveness of the movement's goals, the movement's success in attaining those goals, the extent to which the movement results in prolonged and meaningful contact between two previously segregated groups, and the extent of the movement's access to existing cultural elites in society.

Breadth of the Movement's Goals

All other things being equal, the more extensive its goals, the more likely that a movement will be a force for cultural change. Given this understanding, it is not surprising that all of the examples of cultural change mentioned in the previous section are the products of movements whose goals were very broad. Revolutionary movements have the broadest goals; they seek nothing less than the replacement of an existing political, economic, and social order. Accordingly, of all types of movements, revolutions typically have the greatest potential for stimulating significant cultural change. Given their fundamental interest in replacing the old regime, insurgents will almost invariably seek to destroy the cultural expressions of the old order and substitute a new revolutionary culture in its place (Gramsci 1971). At the other end of the revolution to reform continuum, movements of the narrow reform variety typically exert little cultural force. For example, the current anti-drunk driving movement has but a few if any cultural, as opposed to legal or political, implications. Its goals are simply so narrow and so specific as to rule out any broader cultural critique of American society.

The Degree of Success Achieved by the Movement

History, as the old saying goes, is written by the winners. The same is true for all major forms of cultural expression. A second determinant, therefore, of the cultural impact of a movement is the degree to which the movement is successful politically. Following Marx (1977), it would seem to be the case that cultural dominance rests, to a large extent, on a firm political and economic base. Accordingly, I hypothesize that the cultural impact of a movement will be commensurate with the substantive political and economic success it achieves. Again, this is most evident in the case of successful revolutions, wherein the

victors move to eradicate the cultural, as well as political, vestiges of the old regime and to popularize cultural forms expressive of the new revolutionary order. At the other extreme, movements that fail to achieve any political leverage typically leave few cultural traces behind.

Contact between Previously Segregated Groups

Those movements that have been especially important as sources of cultural innovation would seem to be those that resulted in meaningful, that is, egalitarian, contact between previously segregated social strata. The significance of this kind of contact—the interaction between what Harrison White (1991) calls two “value streams”—is its potential to produce a new cultural hybrid based on the two subcultures present in the movement. Movements of this type have been among the most important in human history.

The early Christian movement represented a unique cultural hybrid based on a merger of a rural ascetic Jewish tradition with that of urban Hellenized Jews and Romans throughout the eastern Mediterranean. The Indian independence movement facilitated unprecedented contact between the untouchables and the most privileged Indian castes. The result was not simply political success but a period of unusual cultural ferment as well. Finally, for a brief period of time, the American civil rights movement encouraged egalitarian contact between black civil rights activists and the white student left. In large measure, the roots of the 1960s counterculture are found in the distinctive cultural hybrid that grew out of this contact (McAdam 1988).

Ties to Established Cultural Elites

The final factor that can be expected to shape the broader cultural impact of a movement is the extent to which it is linked to established cultural elites in society. One of the commonplace observations concerning the cultural ferment of the 1960s was that it represented “culture from the bottom up.” Instead of cultural innovation flowing, as it normally does, from an established cultural elite downward through society, it seemed to emanate from groups whose impact on mainstream culture is ordinarily quite small. What this observation misses is the fact that the groups in question had unusually strong ties to established

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cultural elites, thus granting them more access to the means of cultural production than they ordinarily would have had. The ties forged in the early days of the movement between civil rights activists and segments of the Northern intellectual and cultural elite afforded blacks increased opportunities for cultural influence. The white student left, dominated as it was by middle- and upper-middle-class youth, enjoyed considerable access to the means of cultural expression via their parents and other influential adults to whom they were directly or indirectly linked. Generally, those movements that are either rooted in culturally privileged classes or that are able to forge such links are likely to have a greater impact on the cultural contours of mainstream society than those movements that remain fundamentally isolated from the established means of cultural production.

Conclusion

What I offer here is the most preliminary statement of the relationship between culture and social movements. The topic is complex and multifaceted. These are the beginnings of what I hope will be an ongoing discourse on the subject by both movement scholars and cultural analysts. Only by encouraging such a discourse can we hope to move toward a fuller understanding of this relationship and move beyond the current structural and rationalist biases evident in the contemporary movement literature.

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to Identity

**Edited by
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Joseph R. Gusfield**



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